



"To be pleasant,
gentle, calm ...
this is the basis
**of good taste
and charm in
a woman."**

MURASAKI SHIKIBU, *THE DIARY OF LADY MURASAKI*,
JAPAN, 11TH CENTURY

LESSONS IN PROPRIETY

Women during Japan's Heian period were expected to be beautiful and to be quiet. Written by lady-in-waiting Murasaki Shikibu (left), the *Tale of Genji* is not only a novel but a key insight into Heian-era courtship. Shikibu's work, which spans 53 chapters, describes the intrigues of Heian court life and gives a sense of the propriety and good taste that governed courtship and seduction. The exchange of poetry, for example, was an essential part of courting etiquette, and men and women disliked seeing each other naked—even during intercourse. Noblewomen like Murasaki lived meekly and respectably, their silk-draped bodies hidden from male eyes behind veils and screens.